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INTERPERSONAL CONTEXT AT WORK AND THE FREQUENCY, APPRAISAL, AND CONSEQUENCES OF BOUNDARY-SPANNING DEMANDS

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Compared to job-specific conditions, the interpersonal context of work has received less attention from work–family scholars. Using data from a 2007 U.S. survey of workers ($N = 1,286$), we examine the impact of workplace social support and interpersonal conflict on work–family conflict and exposure to boundary-spanning demands—as indexed by the frequency that workers receive work-related contact outside of normal work hours. Findings indicate that workplace social support is associated negatively with work-to-family conflict, while interpersonal conflict at work is associated with higher levels of work-to-family conflict. Results also indicate that both supportive and conflictive work contexts are associated with more frequent exposure to boundary-spanning demands. However, workers in supportive contexts are more likely to *appraise* these demands as beneficial for accomplishing work tasks, and are less likely to appraise them as disruptive to family roles. By contrast, workers in conflictive contexts are more likely to appraise demands as disruptive to family roles, and are less likely to appraise them as beneficial for paid work. Consequently, our findings underscore the resource and demands aspects of interpersonal work contexts and their implications for the work–family interface.

Having long recognized that work and family are interconnected domains, work–family scholars have attempted to document the social-structural factors that influence the ways that individuals experience this interface. These efforts have become increasingly relevant in recent decades that have witnessed the rise of the dual earner household, as well as growing organizational pressures for a flexible and contingent labor force (Vallas 1999; Jacobs and Gerson 2004). Consequently, a majority of American workers and their families now report difficulties with balancing work and family life (Winslow 2005). In an attempt to understand these difficulties, researchers have paid particular attention to the domain of paid work and the ways that certain work conditions, such as the timing, duration and activities of work, shape individuals' efforts to balance work and family roles (see Byron 2005 for a review). However, work–family scholars have tended to overlook the relevance of the *interpersonal context* in which work is performed. The workplace is an important source of relationships that may be supportive and/or

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antagonistic (Andersson and Pearson 1999; Hodson 2001). Yet, while research has demonstrated the importance of workplace relationships for a range of psychosocial and organizational outcomes (Maslach, Schaufeli, and Leiter 2001; Blader and Tyler 2003), their implications for the work–family interface remain understudied (see Mennino, Rubin, and Brayfield 2005 for an exception).

In this article, we draw upon the job demands–resources model—which suggests that work conditions are organized in two broad categories of demands and resources—to examine how supportive and conflictive interpersonal work contexts serve to reduce or increase work-to-family conflict (Bakker and Geurts 2004).¹ As a resource, workplace social support may help to buffer stressful work experiences and reduce the likelihood of negative spillover into the family domain (Billings and Moos 1982). Further, supportive relationships act as enabling resources that help workers to actively balance work and family responsibilities (e.g., coworkers covering shifts for one another). Conversely, antagonistic relationships with coworkers or supervisors may exert physical or psychological demands on individuals, and subsequently reduce their ability to perform nonpaid work tasks adequately (Dormann and Zapf 2002; Pousette and Hanse 2002; Sparks, Faragher, and Cooper 2001; Voydanoff 2007). To our knowledge, no study has examined the ways that *both* workplace social support and interpersonal conflict are related to work-to-family conflict.

In examining the relevance of interpersonal work contexts to the work–family interface, we also demonstrate how these contexts shape exposure to work demands outside of the traditional domain of paid work. Specifically, we examine the extent that individuals receive work-related contact outside of normal working hours. The proliferation of communications devices that allow workers to remain connected to the workplace at all times has meant that such forms of contact are becoming an increasingly common and problematic experience for many individuals (Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006). As such, Voydanoff (2007) conceptualizes this contact as a *boundary-spanning demand* that is shown to be associated positively with work-to-family conflict (Schieman and Glavin 2008). As work-based resources/demands, we suggest that workplace social support and interpersonal conflict influence the frequency that workers are exposed to this boundary-spanning demand, as well as the subsequent impact on work and family roles.

Thus, in an effort to expand the scope of prior research, we ask three questions: (1) How are social support and interpersonal conflict in the workplace associated with work-to-family conflict? (2) Does support and conflict influence the frequency that workers experience boundary-spanning demands, as indexed by the frequency of receiving work-related contact outside of normal work hours? And, (3) Among workers who experience boundary-spanning demands, how does support and conflict influence the extent that these demands are appraised as beneficial to work roles, and appraised as disruptive to family and nonwork roles? In the following sections we review the literature on interpersonal work contexts, focusing on the ways that these contexts influence the extent of spillover of work strains and demands into family and nonwork roles.

BACKGROUND

The “Informal” Context of Work

Numerous studies have documented the ways in which the informal context of paid work influences how workers experience and navigate the work–family interface (Mennino, Rubin, and Brayfield 2005; Voydanoff 2005a; Dikkers et al. 2007; Major et al. 2007). The culture of a workplace, for example, has been found to influence the extent that workers use formal work–family benefits. Perlow (1995) observes how engineers in a competitive work environment were reluctant to take advantage of work–family programs because of the fear it might harm their career. In another study, Mennino et al. (2005) find that a family-friendly work culture was more important for reducing work-to-family conflict than the actual availability of formal work-life policies. Voydanoff (2005b) also finds that an unsupportive work–family culture is associated with higher levels of work-to-family conflict among a nationally representative sample of American workers.

The informal culture of the workplace is not a static entity, however—it is enacted and re-created through the daily web of workplace interactions among coworkers, supervisors, and clients. While a vast body of research has documented how social relationships convey advantage and disadvantage, dating back to the work of the early exchange theorists (Homans 1950), and continued through the work of social capital researchers (Lin 1999; Cranford 2005), work–family scholars have only recently come to recognize the importance of interpersonal work relationships to the work–family interface (Moen and Yu 2000; Kinnunen et al. 2005; Mennino et al. 2005). Moreover, studies that have examined workplace relations usually focus on the integrative or network-structure aspects of social support. However, support is only one feature of interpersonal relationships; *conflicts* are also important (House, Umberson, and Landis 1988; Thoits 1995). In the following sections we review research on workplace social support and interpersonal conflict with regards to the work–family interface.

Workplace Social Support and Interpersonal Conflict

Research on work relationships has mainly focused on their supportive and beneficial aspects. This research has consistently demonstrated how workplace social support helps workers buffer work strains and reduce the interference of job demands on family activities and responsibilities (Moen and Yu 2000; Major et al. 2007). Moen and Yu (2000), for example, find that having a supportive supervisor is associated with lower levels of job stress and work–family conflict. Similarly, O’Driscoll et al. (2003) find that supervisor support is associated lower levels of psychological strain among workers. Support from coworkers has also been linked to lower levels of work–family conflict (Carlson and Perrewé 1999; McManus et al. 2002; Thompson and Prottas 2006).

Workplace social support therefore has dual benefits for workers. First, it can buffer against the psychological demands and stresses of work, reducing the likelihood of negative work–family spillover. Second, it provides a context that facilitates workers’ attempts to balance work and family roles. In accordance with the job demands–

resources model (Bakker and Geurts 2004), then, we propose the following *interpersonal resource* hypothesis: Individuals in workplace contexts with more social support should report lower levels of work-to-family conflict.

Compared to social support, interpersonal conflict in the workplace has received less attention from work–family scholars. Despite this, interpersonal conflict is argued to be one of the most prevalent and consequential stressors in the workplace (Keenan and Newton 1985; Bolger et al. 1989; Hahn 2000). We conceptualize interpersonal conflict as including a range of negative interpersonal experiences in the work role: such as resistance, conflict, undermining, and antagonistic negotiation between coworkers, supervisors, and clients/customers (Dormann and Zapf 2002). One possible reason why interpersonal conflict has been less studied in comparison to workplace social support is that it may involve both direct exchanges between individuals and also indirect exchanges—such as coworkers talking about an individual behind their back. The subtle, yet insidious nature of these negative exchanges makes them difficult to measure; but their effects on the individual are nevertheless real. Research has demonstrated, for example, that workplace interpersonal conflict is associated with a range of negative individual outcomes, including physical symptoms, distress, and job dissatisfaction (Sparks et al. 2001; Dormann and Zapf 2002; Pousette and Hanse 2002; Taris, Kalimo, and Schaufeli 2002; Van Veldhoven et al. 2002).

While the work–family implications of workplace interpersonal conflict remain understudied, research suggests that, as a job stressor, conflict increases the spillover of job strain and psychological distress into family and nonwork roles (Geurts and Demerouti 2003). Prior research suggests that workers may continue to feel the residual effects of antagonistic or hostile work encounters even after they leave the problematic climate. Smith et al. (1988), for example, find that the experience of hostile relations with coworkers is associated with lower levels of family cohesiveness. Likewise, Bolger et al. (1989) find that workers who experienced arguments with coworkers were more likely to argue with their spouse at home. This research suggests that as job stressor, interpersonal conflict at work is easily carried over into nonpaid work roles and activities. Drawing upon these ideas, we propose the *interpersonal demand* hypothesis: Workers with more interpersonal conflict at work should report higher levels of work-to-family conflict.

Interpersonal Contexts and Boundary-Spanning Demands

Workplace interpersonal conflict may also influence family roles through processes separate from the spillover of job strain and negative affect—they may increase the extent that individuals are exposed to work demands *outside of the workplace*. Workplace acts of disagreement, friction, and even sabotage, typically arise from and sustain individual-oriented and competitive-based work environments (Salin 2003). These work contexts may hinder the performance of work roles as well as the performance of nonpaid work roles in various ways. In a study of female engineers, for example, Fletcher (1999) observes how a competitive work culture and unsupportive relationships undermine and devalue interpersonal work skills. Female engineers who attempted to engage in mutually beneficial activities, such as sharing information, were either ignored or

exploited by other competitive engineers in the organization. The unsupportive nature of these interactions reflects a lack of respect and consideration for the work behaviors of fellow workers (Fletcher 1999). We propose that these interpersonal contexts are also likely to engender a similar lack of respect for the boundaries that delineate work from nonpaid work roles. Thus, coworkers and supervisors in these contexts may be more likely to make demands on workers that extend outside of the traditional domain of work. Voydanoff (2007) refers to these requests as a type of *boundary-spanning demand*, finding them to be associated positively with work-to-family conflict. With recent advances in communications technologies, these demands have become increasingly relevant to the work–family interface since they challenge the notion of work and family as separate and stable spheres.

While mobile communication technologies (e.g., laptops, smartphones) have become increasingly common and synonymous to many forms of work (Chesley 2005; Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006), research has offered mixed findings on the work-life implications of these devices, which allow individuals to be “always accessible” to both work roles and family roles, anytime, anywhere. Some have argued that communication technologies have positive implications for the work–family interface because they provide workers with the flexibility to juggle work and domestic responsibilities (Hill et al. 2001; Valcour and Hunter 2005). Others contend, however, that these technologies expand the ways that work can encroach upon and gain primacy over nonpaid work roles (Kraut et al. 1998; Galinsky, Kim, and Bond 2001). For example, e-mail and cell phones may expose individuals to *more* work demands, since it is possible for individuals to be contacted outside of the work role, as well as during normal working hours. We suggest these boundary-spanning demands are more likely to occur in workplace contexts characterized by interpersonal conflict, where coworkers and supervisors are less likely to respect the normative boundaries separating work and family. Thus, the *interpersonal demand* hypothesis predicts that workplace interpersonal conflict is associated with *more frequent* exposure to boundary-spanning demands in the form of work contact outside of normal work hours. By contrast, the *interpersonal resource* hypothesis predicts that workplace social support is associated with *less frequent* exposure to these demands.

Appraisals of Boundary-Spanning Demands

One caveat associated with the boundary-spanning demand that we examine—receiving work contact outside of normal work hours—is that it is implicitly assumed that these demands represent an undesirable work–family configuration, inferred from previous research that documents a positive association with work-to-family conflict (Voydanoff 2005b). Despite this, there are circumstances in which receiving this form of contact may reflect *desirable* work–family arrangements that benefit work and/or family roles. To assess these different possibilities, we consider the extent that workers *appraise* contact outside of normal work hours as (1) beneficial to their work role and (2) detrimental to their family role. These questions provide a closer examination of the work–family implications of boundary-spanning demands that occur in the context of workplace

social support and interpersonal conflict. From the perspective of the job demands–resources model (Bakker and Geurts 2004), workplace social support should act as a resource for workers by facilitating work contact that benefits both work and family roles. For example, a worker at home might be alerted by coworkers by phone about emerging work problems that require immediate attention; this might help workers avoid more serious problems that would necessitate their actual physical presence at work. Conversely, interpersonal conflict at work represents a demanding context that encourages undesirable and antagonistic forms of work contact (e.g., receiving frequent requests for updates on work-related tasks from supervisors or coworkers).

Accordingly, the *interpersonal demand* hypothesis predicts that boundary-spanning demands that occur in more supportive work contexts should be appraised as *less* useful for the work role and *more* detrimental for family roles. By contrast, the *interpersonal resource* hypothesis predicts that boundary-spanning demands that occur in workplace contexts with more interpersonal conflict should be appraised as *more* useful for the work role and *less* detrimental for family roles.

To test these hypotheses, we use a multistage strategy that examines how reports of workplace social support and interpersonal conflict are separately associated with work-to-family conflict, boundary-spanning demands, and worker appraisals of these demands. To do this, we employ separate regression analyses with work–family conflict, boundary-spanning demands, and their appraisals as dependent variables, predicted by workplace social support and interpersonal conflict. This analytical strategy is described in more detail in the following methods section.

METHOD

Sample

The data were derived from telephone interviews with 1,800 adults in the 50 U.S. states in 2005.² Eligible participants are 18 years of age or older and participating in the paid labor force. Interviews were conducted in English, so participants had to be sufficiently fluent in order to complete the interview. We successfully interviewed 71 percent of eligible individuals. The age range of this sample is 18–94, with a mean of 43.51 (standard deviation = 13.21). Approximately 18–20 months after the initial interview, we were able to successfully reinterview 1,286 of the original participants (71.4 percent). Sample characteristics for the second wave are similar to those of the 2005 American Community Survey (ACS).³ In the present analyses, we examine data from the second interview because the measures about boundary-spanning demands and work–family conflict were asked only at the second interview. We excluded participants with missing values on the focal measures, yielding 1,090 cases for the present analyses. In addition, one section of our analyses examines responses to two follow-up questions about the perceived usefulness and disruptiveness of boundary-spanning demands. In those analyses, we excluded individuals who did not experience any boundary-spanning demands, yielding a subset of 775 cases.

Measures

Work-to-Family Conflict

Four items assess the frequency that individuals experienced work-to-family conflict in the past three months: “How often have you not had enough time for your family or other important people in your life because of your job?”, “How often have you not had the energy to do things with your family or other important people in your life because of your job?”, “How often has work kept you from doing as good a job at home as you could?”, and “How often has your job kept you from concentrating on important things in your family and personal life?” Response choices are coded as “never” (1), “rarely” (2), “sometimes” (3), “often” (4), and “very often” (5). We averaged items such that higher scores indicate higher work-to-family conflict ($\alpha = .85$).

Workplace Interpersonal Conflict

Participants were asked to report the extent of exposure to a variety of work-based interpersonal problems in the past 30 days with the following items: (1) “someone treated you unfairly,” (2) “someone blamed or criticized you for something that wasn’t your fault,” (3) “someone did not do the work that needed to be done or did it in a sloppy or incompetent way,” (4) “someone got annoyed or angry with you,” (5) “someone gossiped or talked about you behind your back,” (6) “someone teased or nagged you,” (7) “someone gave you unclear directions about work you needed to do,” and (8) “someone made too many demands on you.” Participants were also asked to rate the frequency of exposure to each of these indicators from all sources in the workplace, including supervisors, supervisees, customers/clients, coworkers, or anyone else in the workplace. Response choices are coded as (0) “never,” (1) “rarely,” (2) “sometimes,” or (3) “frequently.” We summed responses to create the index of interpersonal conflict in the workplace ($\alpha = .73$).

Workplace Social Support

Participants were asked to report the extent that they experienced social support in the workplace with the following items: (1) “someone listened to your ideas or opinions,” (2) “someone thanked you for the work you do,” (3) “someone gave you positive feedback, guidance, or advice,” and (4) “someone said or did something that made you feel pride in your work.” Following the same logic used to create the interpersonal conflict measure, we summed responses to create an index of interpersonal social support in the workplace ($\alpha = .74$).

Boundary-Spanning Demands

Frequency

We use one item to assess the frequency of exposure to the following boundary-spanning demand: “How often do coworkers, supervisors, managers, customers, or clients contact you about work-related matters outside normal work hours? Include telephone, cell phone, beeper and pager calls, as well as faxes and e-mail that you have to respond to.” Response choices are coded as follows: (1) never, (2) less than once a month,

(3) once a week, (4) several times a week, and (5) once or more times a day. Individuals who reported that receiving work-related contact was “not relevant” for their job were coded as “never.” This item is identical to that used in the 2002 National Survey of the Changing Workforce (NSCW) and has been analyzed by Voydanoff (2005b) in recently published research.

Appraisals

Disruptive to family and nonwork roles: To assess the extent that receiving work-related contact is disruptive to nonpaid work roles, we asked a follow-up question of participants who reported any level of contact: “When this happens (being contacted outside work hours), how disruptive is it to your personal or social life?” Response choices were assessed on a 5-point scale that ranged from (1) “not at all disruptive” to (5) “extremely disruptive.” *Beneficial to the work role:* To assess the extent that receiving work-related contact is beneficial to work roles, we asked another follow-up question of participants who reported some level of contact: “When this happens (being contacted outside work hours), how helpful or useful is this contact for getting your work done?” Response choices were coded on a 5-point scale that ranged from (1) “not at all helpful or useful” to (5) “extremely helpful or useful.”

Gender

We use dummy codes for men (0) and women (1).

Age

Age is coded in years.

Education

Education is coded as (1) some high school but did not graduate, (2) high school graduate/GED, (3) specialized vocational training/some college, (4) Associate’s Degree, (5), college graduate (BA or BS), and (6) postgraduate—advanced degree (MA, PhD).

Occupation

To assess occupation, we asked participants about the job title of the “main job at which you worked last week.” This question refers to their main place of employment; that is, the one that participants spend most time at. We also asked about some of the main duties in order to more accurately code responses. Using the open-ended information provided, we coded responses into five main categories in accordance with the Bureau of Labor Statistics codes. These include “professional” (managerial and professional specialty occupations), “administrative” (technical, sales, and administrative support occupations), “service” (service occupations), “craft” (precision production, craft, and repair occupations), and “labor” (operators or laborers). In regression analyses, we use *professional* as the omitted reference category.

Work Hours

We contrast participants who work “50 hours or more per week” with workers in two other categories: “40–49 hours per week” and “fewer than 40 hours per week.”

Schedule Control

One question asks about schedule control: “Who usually decides when you start and finish work each day at your main job? Is it someone else, or can you decide within certain limits, or are you entirely free to decide when you start and finish work?” We coded responses as “no schedule control” (0), “some control” (1), and “full control” (2). In regression analyses, individuals with no schedule control are the omitted/contrast category.

Personal Income

Income is assessed with the question: “For the complete year of 2004, what was your total personal income, including income from all of your paid jobs, before taxes?”

Number of Coworkers

We include a count of the total number of coworkers, supervisors and clients that respondents report having personal contact with (either in-person or remotely) through their work role. Logged scores are used.

Role-Set Multiplicity

Four items are used to assess role-set multiplicity: (1) “Do you have a supervisor or manager?”; (2) “Do you supervise or manage anyone as part of your job?”; (3) “Do you have clients or customers with whom you have personal contact? (By “personal contact” we mean you interact with them directly in person, by phone, or e-mail.)”; and (4) “Other than the people we just talked about, are there any other people at your workplace with whom you have personal contact, such as coworkers?” Responses for each question are coded “no” = 0, “yes” = 1. We summed the items to create the role-set multiplicity index.

Basic Control Measures

For race, we contrast “white” (1) versus all other categories (0). For marital status, we use “married” as the omitted reference category and contrast against “never married” and “previously married” in regression analyses. One item assesses whether participants have a spouse/partner who is currently working full time (1) versus all others (0). We included a measure of the total number of children under the age of 18 residing in the household.

Without outlining the details of *each* specific potential influence of our control measures, we briefly explain our rationale for their inclusion. We adjust for these controls because they may influence our focal associations. Age, race, marital status, and the presence of children in the household are basic control measures found in most work–family interface research. In the case of age, for example, the few population-based

studies that have assessed age patterns yield mixed conclusions. Some have found that age is associated negatively (and linearly) with work-to-family conflict (Mennino et al. 2005), while others document that workers in middle adulthood report the highest levels of work-to-family conflict (Grzywacz, Almeida, and McDonald 2002; Bellavia and Frone 2005). Although less is known about the influence of race, there are indications that statuses associated with the home role influence various aspects of the work-home interface (see Jacobs and Gerson 2004). In addition, it is apparent that education, occupation, and work hours may have influential consequences on the measures involved in our hypothesized focal associations. For example, the well-educated and professionals report higher levels boundary-spanning demands and work-to-family conflict (Schieman, Kurashina, and Van Gundy 2006; Schieman and Glavin 2008). Further, since it is possible that individuals with larger and/or more diverse work-role sets may experience both higher levels of workplace social support/conflict and work contact, we include role-set multiplicity and number of coworkers in order to rule out any spurious association between supportive/conflictive work contexts and boundary-spanning demands.

Plan of Analyses

Table 1 reports descriptive statistics. In Tables 2 and 3, we present multivariate analyses to test the *interpersonal demands/resources* hypotheses; all models use ordinary least squares (OLS) regression techniques. In Table 2 we present the separate effects of workplace social support and interpersonal conflict on the dependent variable: work-to-family conflict. Model 1 regresses work-to-family conflict on workplace social support and interpersonal conflict to test the resource/demand hypotheses that social support (interpersonal conflict) reduces (increases) conflict. Model 2 includes boundary-spanning demands to assess their contribution to any observed associations. In Table 3 we present three separate regression analyses to examine how workplace social support and interpersonal conflict are associated with boundary-spanning demands. We first regress frequency of boundary-spanning demands on workplace social support and interpersonal conflict to test the resource/demand hypotheses that support (conflict) reduces (increases) exposure to boundary-spanning demands. We then regress the extent that workers appraise these demands as *beneficial* for the work role on workplace social support and interpersonal conflict. Finally, we regress the extent that workers appraise these demands as *disruptive* for family roles on workplace social support and interpersonal conflict. All analyses adjust for respondent demographics and job conditions.

RESULTS

Interpersonal Work Context and Work-to-Family Conflict

Model 1 of Table 2 indicates that individuals who receive more social support at work tend to report lower levels of work-to-family conflict. By contrast, exposure to interpersonal conflict at work is associated with elevated levels of work-to-family conflict. We therefore find initial support for both the *interpersonal resource* and *interpersonal demand*

TABLE 1. Descriptive Statistics for All Study Variables

	Total (N = 1,090)
Focal measures	
Work-to-family conflict	2.34
Social support at work	14.56
Interpersonal conflict at work	5.80
Boundary-spanning demands	2.48
Control measures	
Women	.58
Age	44.94
Education	3.78
Married	.63
Previously married	.21
Never married	.16
Spouse/partner works full time	.43
Spouse/partner works part time	.07
Children in household	.78
White	.77
Service occupations	.14
Administrative support occupations	.38
Craft occupations	.07
Labor occupations	.08
Professional occupations	.33
Income	50,437.28
Work hours (fewer than 40)	.28
Work hours (40 to 49)	.44
Work hours (50 and above)	.28
Full schedule control	.19
Some schedule control	.38
No schedule control	.43
Role-set multiplicity	2.62
Number of coworkers	60.85

hypotheses. In model 2 of Table 2 we observe that individuals who are more frequently exposed to boundary-spanning demands tend to report higher levels of work-to-family conflict. The inclusion of boundary-spanning demands does not affect the associations between social support/interpersonal conflict and work-to-family conflict. Additionally, standardized regression coefficients indicate that the positive association between interpersonal conflict and work-to-family conflict is considerably stronger in comparison to the negative association between social support and work-to-family conflict.

Among the control measures we observe that women, those with children in the household, and those who work long hours report significantly higher levels of work-to-family conflict. Conversely, those with a partner who works full-time and those reporting full schedule control experience lower levels of work-to-family conflict. In

TABLE 2. Regression of Work-to-Family Conflict on Workplace Social Support and Interpersonal Conflict, and Boundary-Spanning Demands

	Model 1		Model 2	
	b	beta	b	beta
Focal associations				
Social support at work	-.01**	-.08	-.01**	-.09
Interpersonal conflict at work	.04***	.29	.03**	.28
Boundary-spanning demands	—	—	.09***	.15
Control measures				
Women	.15**	.09	.18***	.11
Age	-.01	-.03	-.01	-.03
Education	.02	.04	.01	.03
Previously married ^a	-.08	-.04	-.12	-.06
Never married ^a	-.11	-.05	-.11	-.06
Spouse/partner works full time ^b	-.11*	-.07	-.13*	-.08
Spouse/partner works part time ^b	-.01	-.01	-.03	-.01
Children in household	.05*	.06	.05*	.07
White	.06	.02	.04	.02
Service ^c	.08	.01	.09	.02
Administrative ^c	-.13*	-.08	-.10*	-.06
Craft ^c	-.09	-.04	-.08	-.03
Labor ^c	-.03	-.02	.04	.01
Income ^c	.04	.05	.04	.05
Work hours (1–39) ^d	-.46***	-.27	-.44***	-.25
Work hours (40–49) ^d	-.42***	-.27	-.38***	-.24
Full schedule control ^e	-.08***	-.04	-.16**	-.08
Some schedule control ^e	.01	.01	-.04	-.01
Role-set multiplicity	.08**	.09	.07*	.08
Number of coworkers	-.01	-.03	-.02	-.04
Constant	2.47		2.28	
R ²	.22		.24	

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed test).

^aCompared to married.

^bCompared to people with no working partner or spouse.

^cCompared to professional occupations.

^dCompared to 50 hours or more per week.

^eCompared to no schedule control.

analyses not shown, we also tested for interaction effects between frequency of boundary-spanning demands and workplace social support/conflict, but found no statistically significant results.

Interpersonal Work Context and Boundary-Spanning Demands

In Table 3 we observe that both workplace social support and interpersonal conflict are associated with more frequent boundary-spanning demands, indicating support for the

TABLE 3. Regression of the Frequency and Appraisal of Boundary-Spanning Demands (BSDs) on Workplace Social Support and Interpersonal Conflict

	Frequency of BSDs		Beneficial (Work) BSDs		Disruptive (Home) BSDs	
	b	beta	b	beta	b	beta
Focal associations						
Social support at work	.01**	.08	.02***	.15	-.02***	-.12
Interpersonal conflict at work	.02**	.09	-.02*	-.08	.03***	.17
Frequency of BSDs	—	—	.20***	.14	.31***	.28
Control measures						
Women	-.30***	-.12	-.32**	-.11	.21*	.10
Age	-.03	-.03	.01*	.08	-.01	-.05
Education	.05	.06	-.10**	-.11	-.03	-.04
Previously married ^a	.37***	.12	-.11	-.03	-.19	-.07
Never married ^a	.14	.04	-.08	-.02	-.14	-.03
Spouse/partner works full time ^b	.17	.07	-.04	-.02	-.13	-.06
Spouse/partner works part time ^b	.16	.03	-.29	-.05	-.17	-.04
Children in household	-.03	-.03	.02	.02	.02	.02
White	.23**	.08	-.17	-.05	-.04	-.01
Service ^c	-.16	-.05	-.13	-.03	.12	.03
Administrative ^c	-.30**	-.12	.01	.01	-.05	-.03
Craft ^c	-.23	-.05	-.40	-.07	-.06	-.02
Labor ^c	-.53**	-.12	-.60*	-.10	-.17	-.04
Income ^c	.04	.03	-.07	-.06	.11***	.13
Work hours (1–39) ^d	-.23*	-.08	-.01	-.03	.01	.01
Work hours (40–49) ^d	-.52***	-.20	.01	.01	.09	.04
Full schedule control ^e	.87***	.27	.39**	.12	.04	.02
Some schedule control ^e	.28***	.11	.22	.07	.09	.04
Role-set multiplicity	.07	.05	.05	.03	.12*	.09
Number of coworkers	.08**	.10	-.02	-.02	-.03	-.04
Constant	2.06		2.12		1.00	
R ²	.26		.11		.16	

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ (two-tailed test).^aCompared to married.^bCompared to people with no working partner or spouse.^cCompared to professional occupations.^dCompared to 50 hours or more per week.^eCompared to no schedule control.

interpersonal demand hypothesis but not for the *interpersonal resource* hypothesis, which predicts that social support at work should be associated with less frequent boundary-spanning demands. Standardized regression coefficients reveal that the positive association between interpersonal conflict and boundary-spanning demands is only slightly stronger in comparison to the association between social support and boundary-spanning demands.

We then examine the effect of workplace social support and interpersonal conflict on respondents' appraisals of boundary-spanning demands. Individuals with more support at work tend to appraise boundary-spanning demands more favorably for the work role. Further, social support reduces the extent that individuals appraise boundary-spanning demands as disruptive to family and nonwork roles. Together, these results provide support for the *interpersonal resource* hypothesis, which predicts that social support should facilitate work contact that is useful to both work and family roles. By contrast, individuals exposed to interpersonal conflict at work tend to appraise boundary-spanning demands as more disruptive to their personal or social life, and less favorably for the work role—confirming the predictions of the *interpersonal demand* hypothesis that conflict encourages work contact that is nonbeneficial to work roles and disruptive to family roles.

Among the control measures we observe that men report significantly higher levels of boundary-spanning demands, as do those who were previously married, in comparison to the currently married. We also find that those who work long hours and those with full schedule control report significantly higher levels of boundary-spanning demands. The frequency that respondents experience boundary-spanning demands increases both the perceived work role benefits and family-disruptiveness associated with them, while women are less likely to appraise boundary-spanning demands as beneficial for work, and are more likely to appraise them as disruptive to family roles. In observance of prior research that finds marked gender differences in how men and women experience the work–family interface (Blair-Loy 2003), we also tested for gender contingencies in our focal associations between workplace social support/conflict and the frequency and appraisal of boundary-spanning demands; however, these analyses yielded no statistically significant results.

DISCUSSION

Our article makes three central contributions to the work–family interface literature: (1) using the job demands–resources model we examine how interpersonal contexts at work act as resources or demands by documenting how workplace social support and interpersonal conflict are associated with workers' reports of work-to-family conflict; (2) we demonstrate that the frequency and relative impact of a boundary-spanning demand—receiving work contact outside of work—is influenced by the types of interpersonal work contexts workers are exposed; and (3) we address and inform a growing debate on the work-life implications of the use of communication technologies in and outside of the workplace.

The literature on interpersonal work contexts, although somewhat fragmented, suggests that social contexts matter for work-life issues (Bolger et al. 1989; Tausig 1999; Moen and Yu 2000; Voydanoff 2007). Our analyses, based on a large sample of U.S. workers, provide strong support for this assertion: Interpreted from the perspective of the job demands–resources model, interpersonal work contexts act as either resources or demands for individuals attempting to balance work and family roles (Bakker and Geurts 2004). We see evidence of this through the significant associations between workplace social support and interpersonal conflict with respondents' reports of work-to-family conflict. Social support at work is associated with lower levels of work-to-family conflict; by contrast, interpersonal conflict at work is associated with higher levels of work-to-family conflict. This evidence lends support to the *interpersonal resource* and *interpersonal demand* hypotheses. Broadly speaking, these results reinforce the argument that in addition to studying specific characteristics of work, work–family scholars should pay greater attention to the social contexts—both supportive and conflictive—in which work is performed.

We also demonstrate how interpersonal work contexts influence the extent that individuals experience incursions from the work role into nonpaid work domains. Specifically, workplace support and conflict are both associated with higher levels of a boundary-spanning demand: receiving work-related contact outside of normal work hours. At first glance, this would seem to suggest support for our *interpersonal demand* hypothesis and not the *interpersonal resource* hypothesis. However, different patterns emerge when we examine how social support and interpersonal conflict are associated with respondents' appraisals of boundary-spanning demands for work and family roles. Specifically, while support at work is associated with more frequent contact outside of work, our results indicate that in such contexts respondents report this contact as more *beneficial* for work purposes and less disruptive to family and nonwork roles. Thus, boundary-spanning demands that occur in supportive work environments appear to facilitate *efficacious* work–family arrangements that aid the functioning of work roles, with less adverse side effects for nonpaid work roles. By contrast, boundary-spanning demands that occur in contexts characterized by conflict appear to be more disruptive to family and nonwork roles, with little benefit to work roles.

Our observations about the frequency and appraisal of receiving work-related contact outside of normal work hours illuminates the growing debate over the negative versus positive work–family implications of communication technologies (Kraut et al. 1998; Hill et al. 2001; Valcour and Hunter 2005). Cell phones and other technologies that connect individuals to work, regardless of time and place, have double-edged effects: enhanced flexibility at the expense of increased accountability. Separating out these harmful and beneficial effects is a difficult exercise; however, our results underline the value of considering the use of these technologies in the social and cultural contexts that they arise from. That is, contextual factors, such as the interpersonal work environment, are highly influential for processes that determine whether these technologies are useful or harmful to individuals' work and family lives.

Finally, our findings underscore the need for further examination of how interpersonal work contexts act as *demands* on individuals. Previous studies have mainly examined the supportive aspects of the workplace. Our observations reveal that the demanding side of interpersonal contexts may also be critical for the ways that individuals experience and navigate the work–family interface. This is especially apparent when we find that interpersonal conflict at work has a stronger positive association with work-to-family conflict, compared to social support at work. This suggests that, as a work stressor, the deleterious effects of interpersonal conflict (e.g., psychological strain and negative affect) may be more likely to transfer into nonpaid work domains than the positive effects of supportive relationships.

In observing how social support and interpersonal conflict at work *both* increase exposure to boundary-spanning demands, it appears that the demanding nature of interpersonal conflict is more complex than simply its propensity to increase the amount of work contact an individual receives. Rather, examining individuals' appraisals of this contact, it appears that it is the *type of contact* that conflictive contexts encourage that underscores its role as a work demand. This may be a result of the *manner* (e.g., timing, duration) in which contact occurs, as well as the underlying motivation for the integration of work and family roles—from either the perspective of the contactor and contacted individual. While we do not have the data to test these assertions, our findings about the appraisals of boundary-spanning demands within supportive and conflictive work contexts are suggestive of the reasons or possible motivations for this contact. As we have noted, in analyses of the appraisals of boundary-spanning demands, we find that interpersonal conflict at work facilitates work contact that is neither useful to the contacted worker's family role *nor* their work role. The question, then, is: *for whom* is this contact useful? The answer, it would appear, is the coworker, supervisor, or client initiating the contact. In her study of female engineers, Fletcher (1999) discusses how a competitive and individualistic work environment led to uncooperative and potentially exploitive interactions that were detrimental to the work role functioning of the female employees she interviewed. Our examination of boundary-spanning demands in conflictive contexts is suggestive of similarly exploitive interactions occurring *outside* of the work domain, with little apparent regard for workers' personal and social lives. Communication technologies in these contexts may simply extend the reach of exploitive relationships. While an examination of interpersonal work contexts helps us to speculate about the presence of potentially exploitive interactions crossing the work–family border, more detail on the nature of the contact as well as the source (e.g., authority, gender) is necessary to substantiate these conjectures.

We wish to acknowledge several potential limitations of our study. In addition to missing detail on the source and content of the work contact, we are also unable to examine the type of medium used (e.g., phone, e-mail, etc.). All of this information would be helpful in detailing the specific situations and forms of contact that lead to desirable versus undesirable work–family arrangements. Moreover, it would be beneficial to examine work relationships by role-type (e.g., supervisor, subordinate, or

coworker) in order to discover whether certain sources of support and conflict are more important for boundary-spanning demands and their influence on the work–family interface. Also, the use of a single-item measure of work contact may be viewed as a limitation—although it should be noted that it was specifically developed for use in well-respected surveys like the NSCW and found in numerous published research on the work–family interface (e.g., Voydanoff 2005b). Nonetheless, the next step for research is to consider new ways of measuring this type of boundary-spanning demand with multiple items and follow-up questions that expand on the qualitative nature of such demands.

We also suggest several areas that deserve additional attention. While we focus on the implications of boundary-spanning demands for work-to-family conflict, it would be useful to understand how communication technologies facilitate the intrusion of *family and nonwork roles* into the workplace. The portability of such technologies and the difficulty in monitoring their use in the workplace may have serious implications for work role functioning. Here, it might be especially useful to assess the quality of interpersonal support and conflict in the household and the ways those relationships influence the frequency and appraisal of family-to-work boundary-spanning demands. These processes may be particularly important since family-to-work demands may subsequently lead to increased interpersonal conflict at work. The potential cyclical effects of boundary-spanning demands thus warrant longitudinal analyses to map out the precise nature and direction of the work–family mechanisms involved.

Further, there is a need for more research that examines how various dimensions of social stratification influence the patterns documented in this article. As a result of the vast body of evidence that documents how work and family are intrinsically *gendered* domains with gender-specific tasks, responsibilities, and expectations (Blair-Loy 2003), further research is required to examine how boundary-spanning demands are experienced by male and female workers. Our results confirm the gendered spheres argument: men and women in our sample are exposed to different levels of boundary-spanning demands, and appraise their effects on work and family roles differently as well. However, further research is needed to probe these issues in more detail, with greater consideration of how gender inequalities at work and at home influence these processes. It is also likely that the processes examined in this article may differ across age groups since levels of education, authority, and status vary across the lifespan. Young workers, in particular, may experience boundary-spanning demands in different ways from older workers who tend to be less technologically savvy but have higher levels of authority in the workplace. These processes may coincide with important life course patterns in the intersection of family-related statuses of marriage and parenthood (Moen and Yu 2000).

CONCLUSION

In an attempt to understand how individuals manage the often overlapping roles of work and family, work–family scholars have traditionally focused on job-specific attributes that act as resources or demands for achieving desirable work–family

arrangements. The findings of this article confirm and extend previous research that suggests that the social context of paid work is also a relevant work condition in this regard. Social support and interpersonal conflict in the workplace both have important consequences for facilitating desirable versus undesirable work–family arrangements. Thus, as work becomes an increasingly borderless activity for many people, work–family scholars should examine not only how work activities infiltrate family and nonwork domains, but also how the social systems of work become enmeshed with life outside of the workplace, and in turn generate new challenges for workers and their families.

NOTES

¹While we acknowledge that work–family conflict can also entail *family-to-work* conflict, our interest lies in understanding the extent that work *interferes* with family and nonwork roles, which has been documented as more common and severe (Frone 2003; Jacobs and Gerson 2004; Bellavia and Frone 2005).

²To obtain the sample, we used a list-assisted random digit dialing (RDD) selection drawn proportionally from all 50 states from GENESYS Sampling Systems (Marketing Systems Group, 565 Virginia Drive, Fort Washington, PA 19034-2706). The sampling approach employed the List + 1 method, which tends to yield a higher proportion of productive numbers (Lepkowski 1988). List-assisted RDD is widely accepted now by most social survey research organizations as a cost-effective alternative to the pure RDD methods originally developed by Waksberg (1978). List-assisted RDD increases the probability of residential numbers while minimizing the biases often associated with nontraditional RDD techniques. The final sample was based on (1) telephone numbers for residential households, (2) households agreeing to answer screening questions, (3) successfully screened households with one or more employed adults, and (4) eligible households with a subsampled adult who agreed to participate in the interview. The average age is 43.51 years, 59 percent are women, 72 percent are white.

³Sample characteristics for the second wave of the Work, Stress, and Health (WSH) study are similar to the ACS 2005 population estimates, although some differences exist: Women are overrepresented in the present study (60 percent versus 51 percent in the ACS). Age: 18- to 19-year-olds are underrepresented (11 percent versus 22 percent in the ACS), while 50- to 59-year-olds are overrepresented (28.2 percent versus 18.6 percent in the ACS).

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